2.2 Native American Resistance

Sometimes you have to fight for your rights, even when it seems like a losing battle. But the fight is that much harder when the other side doesn't play fair.

MAIN IDEA Some Native Americans took up arms to resist their forced relocation by the U.S. government.

A TRAP IS SET

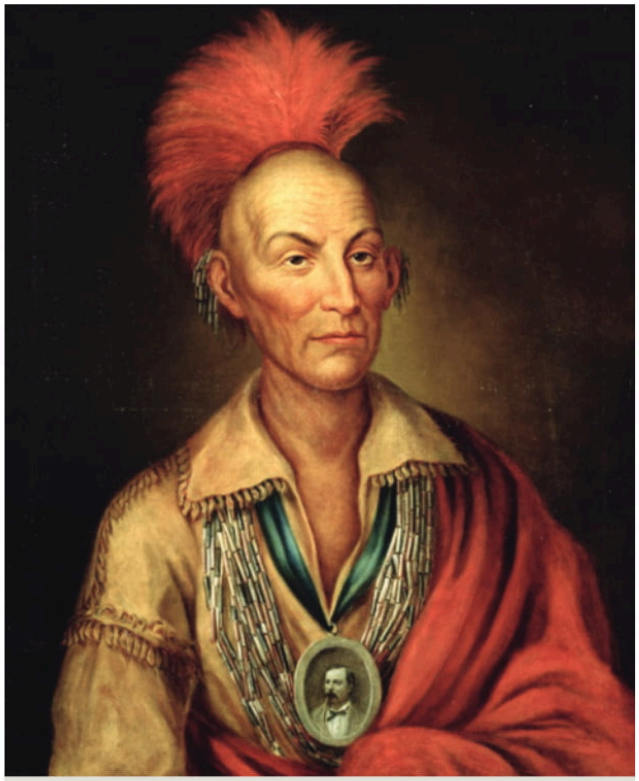
The **Seminole** were among the Native Americans who refused to leave their homes. They lived near the Everglades, a large wetlands region in southern Florida. After the Seminole rejected a removal treaty, President Jackson and the federal government declared war on them in 1835. But it didn't turn out to be an easy fight.

Seminole villages lay deep within the dangerous swampland of the Everglades, providing plenty of places where the Native Americans could hide and giving them a clear geographic advantage. When American soldiers came on the attack, Seminole leader **Osceola** (ahs-ee-OH-luh) and his warriors took them by surprise. They ambushed the soldiers, killing them with their tomahawks and



Threatened by Oil
Some Native Americans continue to protest their treatment today. In this photo, a Native American member of the Cowboy and Indian Alliance joined other Native Americans and non-native protestors in front of the Capitol in Washington, D.C., in April 2014. The thousands who gathered objected to the building of an oil pipeline through their land in the Great Plains region, saying it threatened water and other natural resources.

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Black Hawk

Black Hawk visited Washington, D.C., in 1837 to witness the sale of the last of Sauk land to the United States. During that visit, artist Charles Bird King painted Black Hawk's portrait. Homer Henderson painted this copy in the late 1800s from a print of the original. In the painting, the Native American leader wears a medallion, depicting an unknown man, which he probably received as a treaty gift from U.S. officials.

muskets. The Seminole also burned the homes and crops of American settlers, hoping to drive them from the region.

At the end of 1837, the government arranged to meet with Osceola at a so-called peace conference. The two sides had declared a **truce**, an agreement to stop fighting, while their leaders met to talk. But the meeting was actually a trap. As soon as Osceola arrived, American soldiers took him prisoner. He died three months later in captivity.

Fighting continued off and on for five more years before the Seminole finally surrendered. Some of the Seminole migrated to Indian Territory, but they never entirely left the Everglades. Their descendants continue to live there today.

THE BLACK HAWK WAR

Native Americans in other parts of the country also resisted removal. At first, tribes north of the Ohio River in Illinois, including the Shawnee, Ottawa, Potawatomi, Sauk, and Fox, signed a treaty agreeing to relocate west of the Mississippi River. Once they had moved, however, the Sauk and Fox struggled to grow enough food for their people. They faced starvation. Then, in 1832, they rebelled. A Sauk leader named **Black Hawk** led his people and the Fox back to their lands in Illinois, where they meant to stay.

The U.S. military and Illinois militia had other ideas. To intimidate the Sauk and Fox, troops built large forts in the area. They also recruited members of other Native American tribes to fight Black Hawk and his followers. A young man named **Abraham Lincoln** served as a captain during this campaign. The Black Hawk War dragged on for a few months, but the Sauk and Fox were eventually overpowered. The war was brief but bloody, particularly for the Sauk and Fox. As many as 600 Native Americans died in the fighting, while only about 70 American soldiers perished.

In August 1832, Black Hawk surrendered, and the military imprisoned him for a time in a Virginia fort. He told his captors that he was not sorry for what he'd done. He was defending his land and his people from what he called "cheating men." When the American people read Black Hawk's words, many sympathized with him. Still, the Black Hawk War did not put an end to the government's efforts to drive Native Americans from their lands. Many more would be forced to leave—and at great cost.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Native Americans fight back against attempts to remove them?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How were the reactions of Osceola and Black Hawk similar when they were forced to move westward?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Who were the "cheating men" Black Hawk referred to, and why did he characterize them in that way?

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